The Innovation Lab 2026

ACSS WEEK 2026

Love Mail

Event Primer

Last Updated February 1, 2026

ELIGIBILITY

The Innovation Lab 2026 is open to students who are eager to solve real-world agricultural challenges. To qualify, take note of the rules and eligibility mechanics below:

The challenge is open-for-all university disciplines (IT, Agriculture, Engineering, Business, etc.), provided the solution aligns with the problem domains.

This competition is open exclusively to currently enrolled Undergraduate University Students.

Team Composition: Teams must consist of **3 to 5 members.**

- A minimum of 20 teams must register for Phase 1 (Elimination Round).
- Selected finalist teams will advance to Phase 2 (Final Round).

For teams advancing to the Phase 2: Final Round, each participant must sign and submit the following forms:

Age & Legal Requirements:

- **Participants 18 and Above:** Required to submit a signed Participant Waiver.
- **Participants Below 18:** Required to submit both a Parental Consent Form and a Participant Waiver.

**** These teams will be notified about the consent forms and waivers after the announcement of the finalists.**

PROBLEM DOMAIN

This year's Innovation Lab 2026 centers on the theme **"The Mindful Harvest: Protecting the Hands that Feed Us,"** a challenge specifically designed to address the human element of Philippine agriculture.

Agriculture is a vital sector in the Philippines as it supports food security, livelihoods, and rural communities. However, many of the challenges farmers face occur directly within the farm environment itself, such as managing daily work, staying safe in the field, and handling crops after harvest.

The Innovation Lab 2026 invites participants to develop people-centric technologies that improve everyday life and work inside Filipino farms, while helping build resilient and future-ready farming communities.

Participants are free to work on any innovative solution. They may refer to the list below as suggestions.

1. **Farm Labor and Work Efficiency:**
   Optimizing agronomic interventions and reducing man-days across all stages, from land preparation and sowing to crop maintenance and harvesting.
2. **Farmer Safety, Health, and Well-Being:**
   Minimizing occupational hazards and physical strain during high-intensity field operations.
3. **Farm Sustainability and Resource Management:**
   Precision application of inputs like NPK fertilizers and water to maintain soil health and prevent nutrient leaching.
4. **Compliance:**
   Meeting industry standards and regulatory frameworks, such as PhilGAP (Good Agricultural Practices) or the Organic Agriculture Act (RA 10068).

5. Climate Resilience:

Developing climate-smart systems capable of withstanding abiotic stresses like prolonged drought or flooding from typhoons.

6. Financial Literacy and Social Protection:

Managing farm-gate price fluctuations and securing formal credit through mechanisms like the Agri-Agra Law (RA 10000).

7. Agricultural Education and Knowledge Transfer:

Deploying extension services and technical "know-how" to improve yield gaps without over-complicating the learning process.

8. Post-Harvest Logistics:

Streamlining the cold chain and value chain to minimize post-harvest losses during transport and storage.

9. Farm Ergonomics and Assistive Tools:

Implementing mechanization and tools that reduce the drudgery of repetitive physical labor.

10. Agricultural Extension Communication:

Strengthening the feedback loop between agricultural experts and rural agrarian reform beneficiaries.

COMPETITION FLOW AND FORMAT

OPENING CEREMONY AND WORKSHOP SESSION

The Opening Ceremony and Workshop Session will be conducted during Phase 1 to brief the participants with the contest rules and further equip them with the knowledge and guidance they need to strengthen their proposed solutions. Teams in the Elimination Round are encouraged to attend the workshop. This will be hosted via Zoom and Facebook live.

Sessions will be led by **agricultural stakeholders**, industry professionals, faculty, or other experts. Teams may use this opportunity to clarify technical or domain-related concerns.

NOTE. Attendance for this event will be tracked. At least one member for each participating team must attend this event to qualify for judging. Attendance sheets will be available by the end of the session.

PHASE 1: Elimination Round

The following are the deliverables that the participants must submit to qualify for judging in the elimination round:

1. **Written Proposal**
   Participants are required to submit a 5-page project proposal (.pdf) outlining the development of their solution. The format is as follows:
   a. Executive Summary
      - Provide a brief overview of the project
   b. Problem Statement
      - Describe the challenge or issue that the project tackles
   c. Objectives
      - List the main goals of the project

d. Methodology
   - Describe features and components
   - Provide implementation plans and details
e. Impact
   - Explain the benefits for the target users or communities
f. References
   - In APA 7th Edition format
g. Appendices (Optional)

2. Video Demonstration

Participants are required to record a 2-3 minute video demonstration that showcases the project's functionality and user interactions.

Teams may also submit the following for the elimination round. However, these are completely optional and does not affect scoring or qualification:

***Github Link**

Participants may also submit a GitHub repository link containing the project's source code, documentation, and any additional resources necessary to run the solution.

***Prototype Solution Preview**

They may also submit a Figma design, minimum viable product (MVP), to showcase their current progress.

Judging

All teams who have submitted before the deadline of March 1, 2026 and have attended both the kickoff ceremony and workshop sessions will be considered for judging.

The judging phase will take place over two days (Mar 2–4, 2026). The selected finalists will be notified via email and announced on the official Facebook page on March 4, 2026.

PHASE 2: Final Round and Culmination

The selected finalists will transition into an intensive refinement stage. Finalist teams will have to attend a face-to-face culminating event that will be held on March 7, 2026.

The following are the deliverables that the participants must submit or prepare to qualify for judging in the final round.

1. **Final Pitch Deck**

   Participants must prepare a presentation deck for the live pitch. The deck must include the following sections:

   Problem Statement: A clear definition of the specific agricultural challenge being addressed within the Filipino farm context.

   The Solution: A high-level overview of the proposed technology and how it directly solves the identified problem.

   Technical Methodology: A breakdown of the system architecture, tools used (e.g., specific AI models, IoT hardware, or frameworks), and the core features of the prototype.

Implementation Plan: Details on how the solution would be deployed in a real-world farm environment.

Impact and Scalability: A summary of the tangible benefits for farmers and how the project can grow or be adapted for other agricultural communities.

2. **Final Git Repository**

   A GitHub link containing the finalized source code, with complete documentation and implementation descriptions.

Pitch Format Each team is strictly allotted a 15-minute slot broken down as follows:

- **Pitch (5 Minutes):** Participants will present the project, the problem addressed, and the solution's impact.
- **Demo and Q & A (10 Minutes):** A live walk-through of the functional prototype and questions from the panel of judges.

Mentorship Session

The Mentorship Session will run during Phase 2: Final Round to give the selected teams continuous guidance as they refine their projects. Finalist teams will have to attend an online mentorship session to provide guidance as they prepare for the culmination. This will be hosted on **Zoom**.

DATES

Date	Activity
Phase 1: Elimination Round	
Feb 1 (Sun) - Feb 19 (Thu), 2026	Registration Period
Feb 21 (Sat), 2026	Opening Ceremony & Workshop
Feb 22 (Sun) - Feb 28 (Sat), 2026	Development Block
Mar 1 (Sun), 2026	Submission Deadline
Mar 2 (Mon) - Mar 4 (Wed), 2026	Judging of Submissions
Phase 2: Final Round	
Mar 4 (Wed), 2026	Announcement of Finalists
Mar 5 (Thu), 2026	Mentorship Session
Mar 5 (Thu) - Mar 6 (Fri), 2026	Final Round Preparations
Mar 7 (Sat), 2026	Culmination Day

JUDGING CRITERIA

PHASE 1: Elimination Round

All submissions for the elimination round will be evaluated based on the following criteria:

- **Use of Technology (25%)**
  - Is the proposed technical framework sound and clearly explained, avoiding unnecessary complexity?
  - Is there a clear plan for how the technology will function in a practical agricultural environment ?
- **Design & Usability (20%)**
  - Does the proposed interface prioritize simplicity and ease of use for the target end-user?
  - Is the design focused on essential features that streamline the user's primary tasks?
- **Innovation (20%)**
  - Does the solution offer a unique approach or a significant improvement over existing methods?
  - Does the project demonstrate creative problem-solving in addressing industry-specific challenges?
- **Relevance to the Theme (10%)**
  - Does the project directly contribute to the theme?
- **Feasibility (10%)**
  - Is the project realistic in terms of cost, implementation, and long-term maintenance?
  - Does the team demonstrate an understanding of the resources required to move the project beyond a concept?
- **Presentation (10%)**
  - Is the proposal organized, professional, and effective in communicating the project's value proposition?
- **User Research (5%)**
  - Has the team identified its target stakeholders and provided initial insights or data regarding their needs?

PHASE 2: Final Round

In the F2F final round, judges will evaluate contestants based on the following criteria:

- **Use of Technology - 25%**
  - Is there a functional prototype that demonstrates real technical effort, as opposed to just a simulation?
  - Is the technology a practical fit for the agricultural setting (e.g., does it work offline or in harsh conditions)?
- **Innovation - 20%**
  - Does this offer a genuinely new approach, as opposed to being a copy-paste of an existing solution?
  - Did the team find a "clever" way to bypass a traditional industry hurdle?
- **Design & Usability - 20%**
  - Could a farmer with zero tech training use this interface in the field?
  - Is the design clean, accessible, and focused only on essential features?
- **Relevance to the Theme - 10%**
  - Does the project directly contribute to the theme?
- **User Research - 10%**
  - Did the team provide evidence (quotes, photos, or data) from **interviews with actual agricultural stakeholders**?
  - How much of the project was changed or improved based on real-world feedback?
- **Presentation - 10%**
  - Did the team explain the problem and their solution in a way that anyone could understand in 5 minutes?
- **Q&A and Understanding of Problem - 5%**
  - In the Q&A, did the team show they understand the *root cause* of the problem?

FAQ

Q: Are teams required to attend the opening activity and workshop session?
A: Attendance is required where at least one member of the team must participate to qualify for the next round.

Q: Can we change our team members after the registration period?
A: No. Team compositions are locked once the registration period ends on Feb 18, 2026.

Q: Does the solution have required technical constraints or specifications?
A: Not necessarily. Solutions can be web apps, IoT hardware, or software tools, as long as they address a topic in the problem domain.

Q: What happens if we miss the Phase 1 submission deadline?
A: Late submissions will not be considered for judging. Ensure your 5-page proposal and video are uploaded by March 1, 2026.

Q: Is the Culmination Day face-to-face?
A: Yes. The finalist teams are required to attend the physical event on March 7, 2026.

Q: Are we required to submit a Github link or full prototype during Phase 1: Elimination Round?
A: No. Only the written proposal and video demonstration are required deliverables. However, teams may submit their code and other supplementary materials but these will not be considered in judging. These are only **optional**.